

Web Design

Session 2 - Typography

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Typography and Color

- Typography systems
- Typography groups (sans, serif, display)
- Web fonts & Performance
- Font-sizes and scaling
- Readability, line height, font pairing
- Color theory, contrast, and accessibility (WCAG basics - contrast, sizing)
- Google Fonts and tools for color selection
- Typography with color and images



typescale.com

The Goal

Understand how typography and color
shape **usability**, **readability**, and
brand perception.

Warm-up & Recap

**Use visual hierarchy
to guide the eye**

Key principles of visual hierarchy



Size & Scale

Bigger elements
draw attention first.



Color & contrast

Bright/bold colors stand out.



Position & alignment

Eye moves top → bottom,
left → right (often)



Typography

Headlines vs. subtext styles



Spacing & grouping

White space creates emphasis
and separation.

Create designs **faster** than ever.

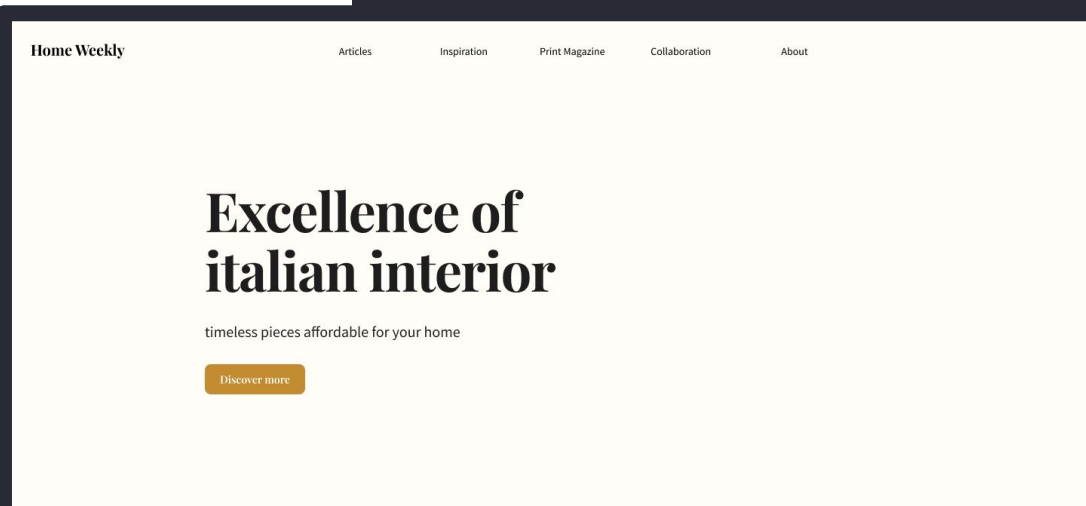
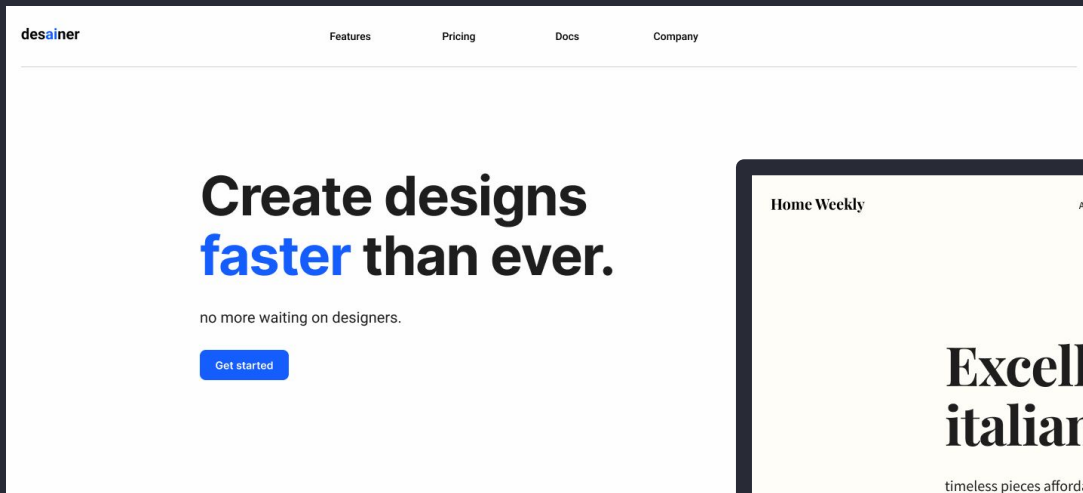
no more waiting on designers.

Get started

Excellence of italian interior

timeless pieces affordable for your home

Discover more



What's different?
What do you expect from both?

[slido.com](https://slido.com/2376622)
2376622

What's different?

Create designs
faster than ever.

no more waiting on designers.

Get started

Inter, Roboto Sans

blue, cold grays

Excellence of
italian interior

timeless pieces affordable for your home

Discover more

Playfair Display, Source Sans

gold, warm grays

What's different?

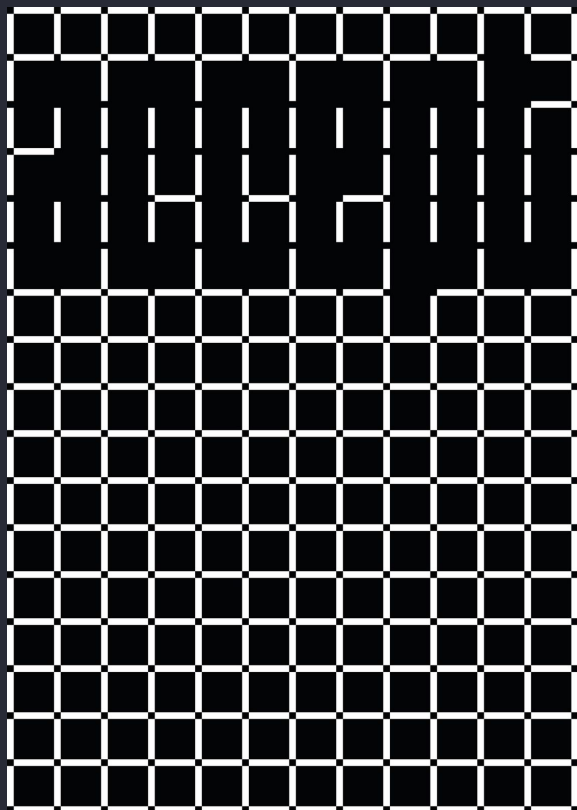
- Same layout, different typefaces
- Tech Startup: *trustworthy, innovative, professional*
- Interior Magazine: *refined, creative, premium*

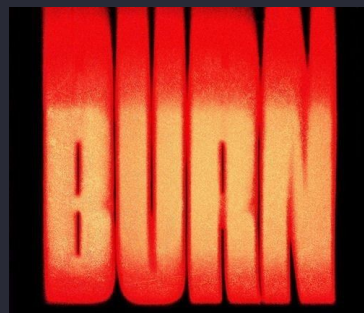
Typography sets **tone** and **brand personality**
even before content is read.

Color communicates **emotion** and **brand context**

Let's see why
both matter equally.

Typography systems and web fonts





ELEVATING SPACES, MASTERING LUXURY

An esteemed atelier of luxurious home and lifestyle brands, Merise establishes its presence in the prestigious Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC), where we invite you to explore a world where elegance meets exclusivity.



MENU



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COLLECTIONS
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[INSTAGRAM](#)

HELLO@MERISE.AE

[DIRECTIONS](#)

What typography does on the web

- There's a lot of text on the web.
- You make a lot of impression with good typography.
- Readability
- Hierarchy
- Emotion

Typographic terms

Typeface

The **overall design** of the letters, numbers, and symbols.

Helvetica

Times New Roman

Garamond

Font

specific instance of a typeface, including its size, weight, and style

12 pt. Helvetica Bold

Family

collection of all fonts with a **common typeface**

Helvetica Regular, Helvetica Bold, Helvetica Italic, Helvetica Light

Anatomy of type



Typeface categories

Serif

Rival's Mounted 012

TIMES NEW ROMAN

Rival's Mounted 012

PLANTIN

Rival's Mounted 012

EQUITY

Sans-serif

Rival's Mounted 012

HELVETICA

Rival's Mounted 012

CONCOURSE

Rival's Mounted 012

HERMES MAIA

Rival's Mounted 012

NEUE HAAS GROTESK

Rival's Mounted 012

ATLAS

Typeface categories

Monospace

Rival's Mounted 012

COURIER NEW

Rival's Mounted 012

TRIPPLICATE

Rival's Mounted 012

PITCH

Rival's Mounted 012

INPUT

Rival's Mounted 012

FIRA MONO

Display

Rival's Mounted 012

PAPYRUS

Rival's Mounted 012

BOOKMAN

Rival's Mounted 012

BODONI

RIVAL'S MOUNTED 012

COPPERPLATE

Rival's Mounted 012

OFFICE SCRIPTS

Serif

- Letters have small **decorative “feet” or strokes** (serifs) at the ends.
- Feels **traditional, formal, and trustworthy** — common in print and editorial design.
- Often used for **body text** in long-form reading or for brands that want a classic tone.

Examples: Times New Roman, Playfair Display, Georgia

Rival's Mounted 012

TIMES NEW ROMAN

Sans-serif

- **No serifs** — clean, simple letterforms with even stroke width.
- Feels **modern, minimal, and approachable**, ideal for digital screens.
- Common in **user interfaces, tech brands, and mobile design** for readability at small sizes.

Examples: Helvetica, Inter, Roboto, Open Sans

Rival's Mounted 012

NEUE HAAS GROTESK

Monospaced

- Every character takes up the same horizontal space.
- Feels **technical** and **structured**, often used in **code** editors or to **convey precision**.
- Works well for **data, terminal, or “techy” aesthetics**, but not for long reading.

Examples: Courier New, IBM Plex Mono, JetBrains Mono, Inconsolata

Rival's Mounted 012

FIRA MONO

Display

- Designed for **large sizes** (headlines, posters), not body text.
- Often highly stylized or decorative, expressing **strong personality**.
- Best for **branding, hero text, or creative projects**, where visual impact matters more than readability.

Examples: Lobster, Abril Fatface, Bebas Neue

Rival's Mounted 012

OFFICE SCRIPTS

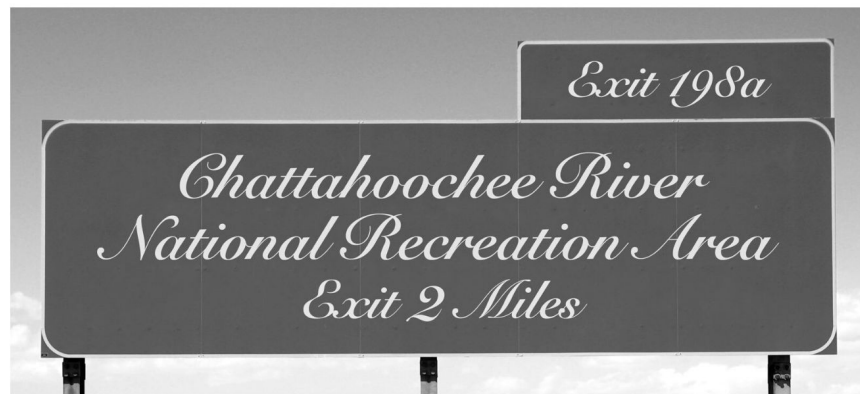
Combine carefully

Choose less, but powerful typefaces, max. 2

Play with typography and stand out

Good typography **reinforces**
the **meaning** of the text.

- ① Good typography is measured by how well it reinforces the meaning of the text, not by some abstract scale of merit. Typographic choices that work for one text won't necessarily work for another. Corollary: good typographers don't rely on rote solutions. One size never fits all.
- ② For a given text, many typographic solutions would work equally well. Typography is not an algebra problem with one correct answer.
- ③ Your ability to produce good typography depends on how well you understand the goals of your text, not on taste or visual training. Corollary: if you misunderstand the goals of your text, good typography becomes purely a matter of luck.







WRONG

WRONG

RIGHT

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Web fonts & performance



Web-Safe Fonts

Installed on almost every device (no download needed).

Limited variety → consistent look across platforms.

Examples: Arial, Georgia, Times New Roman, Verdana.



Reliable but boring.



No external loading → fastest performance.

Web Fonts

Hosted online (e.g., Google Fonts, Adobe Fonts, self-hosted).

Downloaded by the browser when loading a website.

Enables unique branding and better design control.

Each font-weight adds kB → checkout <https://v-fonts.com/>

 Adds network requests → can slow down pages if unoptimized.



Best Practice

Always use modern compressed font formats → .woff2

Smaller file size, faster loading

Widely supported by browsers

Load only the weights/styles you actually use (not the full family).

Define fallback stacks in CSS:

```
font-family: 'Inter', 'Helvetica Neue', Arial, sans-serif;
```

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Font sizes and scaling



<https://nanobanana.ai/> - A new york city skyline with the sun rising but some skyscrapers are letters instead of buildings. Show around 6 skyscrapers with different height as differently sized letters.

Type as toolbox

What tools do you need to build a cabinet?

- Circular Saw
- Electric Drill
- Screws

What types of typo do you need for a website?

- Headings
- Body Text(s)
- Captions

typescale.com

Heading 1

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

72px

line-height

1.1em

letter-spacing

-2px

Heading 2

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

48px

line-height

1.1em

letter-spacing

-1px

Heading 3

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

32px

line-height

1.1em

letter-spacing

-1px

Heading 3

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

32px

line-height

1.1em

letter-spacing

-1px

Text Large

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

20px

line-height

1.4em

letter-spacing

0

Body Text

font-family

IBM Plex Sans

font-weight

regular 400

font-size

16px

line-height

1.5em

letter-spacing

0

Heading 1

font-family	font-weight	font-size	line-height	letter-spacing
IBM Plex Sans	regular 400	72px	1.1em	-2px

Heading 2

font-family	font-weight	font-size	line-height	letter-spacing
IBM Plex Sans	regular 400	48px	1.1em	-1px

Heading 3

font-family	font-weight	font-size	line-height	letter-spacing
IBM Plex Sans	regular 400	32px	1.1em	-1px

Text Large

font-family	font-weight	font-size	line-height	letter-spacing
IBM Plex Sans	regular 400	20px	1.4em	0

Body Text

font-family	font-weight	font-size	line-height	letter-spacing
IBM Plex Sans	regular 400	16px	1.5em	0

Understanding Typographical Hierarchy

Exploring new concepts in a vast world of typography feels overwhelming, but don't be intimidated, follow some simple rules and you will be good to go.

In the world of design, where every pixel and every word counts, effective communication is paramount. One of the most powerful yet often overlooked tools in a designer's arsenal is typographical hierarchy. It's not just about choosing pretty fonts; it's about creating a visual system that guides your reader through content, emphasizing what's important and ensuring a seamless, enjoyable reading experience.

The Pillars of Effective Hierarchy

Establishing a robust typographical hierarchy relies on a few key elements, each playing a crucial role in distinguishing different levels of text. The most common and impactful of these are size and weight. Larger text naturally draws more attention, signaling a primary heading or a key piece of information. Similarly, bolder weights provide emphasis, pulling the eye towards critical points within a paragraph or sub-section.

Crafting a Visual Flow

The ultimate aim of typographical hierarchy is to create a clear, logical, and aesthetically pleasing visual flow. This means that a reader should be able to scan a page or screen and immediately understand the structure of the content, even before reading a single word. A well-executed hierarchy minimizes cognitive load, making it easier for users to digest information efficiently. It moves beyond mere aesthetics, becoming a foundational element of functional design.

choose an appropriate

line-height

Understanding
typographical hierarchy

Understanding
typographical hierarchy

Understanding typographical hierarchy

- Larger font-size → less line-height
- Make sure descenders (g) and ascenders (f) are not touching
- Stay around 1.0 (100%) to 1.3 (130%)

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Line-height - Body Text

- Smaller font-size → more line-height
- Make sure descenders (g) and ascenders (f) are not touching
- Stay around 1.4 (140%) to 1.6 (160%)

paragraph width
of 60–75 characters

60–75 characters

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no justified text

(Blocksatz)

No justified text

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prefer **left-aligned**
over centered text

Prefer **left-aligned** instead of centered text

The Pillars of Effective Hierarchy

Establishing a robust typographical hierarchy relies on a few key elements

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Prefer **left-aligned** instead of centered

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Accessible Type

Accessibility is designing
for the **users preferences**

... and they are diverse!

Key rules

- Clear letterforms, good x-height, simple shapes.
- Enough spacing between letters and lines.
- Consistent: Avoid mixing too many typefaces or weights.



If you have to squint, it's not accessible.

Key rules

- Prefer sans-serif or clean serif families for screen readability.
- Ensure contrast ratio $\geq 4.5 : 1$ between text and background (WCAG AA).
- Don't rely on color alone → emphasize with weight or underline.
- Test with tools like WebAIM Contrast Checker, Figma Color Contrast Checker or *Stark* Plugin in Figma.

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Finally ...

FEMPUTATIONS | TUMBLR

COLOR



Color Theory & Meaning

How color shapes emotion, hierarchy, and brand perception.



Color Theory & Meaning

How color shapes emotion, hierarchy, and brand perception.



Why does color matter?

- first thing users notice
- builds **emotion and trust** before text does

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Farbkreis nach Johannes Itten - 1961



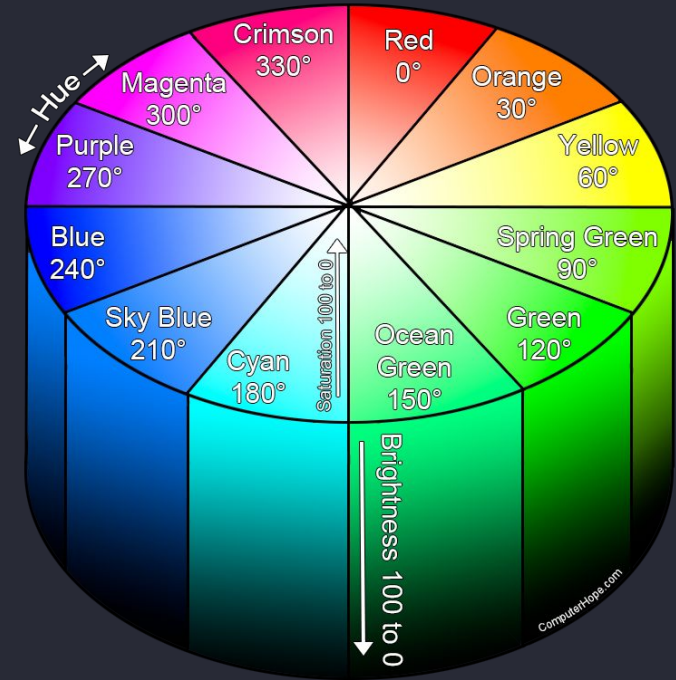
12 Colors

- 3 Primary Colors: RGB
- 3 Secondary Colors: Green, Orange, Purple
- 6 Complementary Colors

Opposites create contrast.

Hue, Saturation, Brightness

- Hue = color family (red, blue, etc.)
- Saturation = intensity of the color.
- Brightness = lightness / darkness.



Saturation in Practice

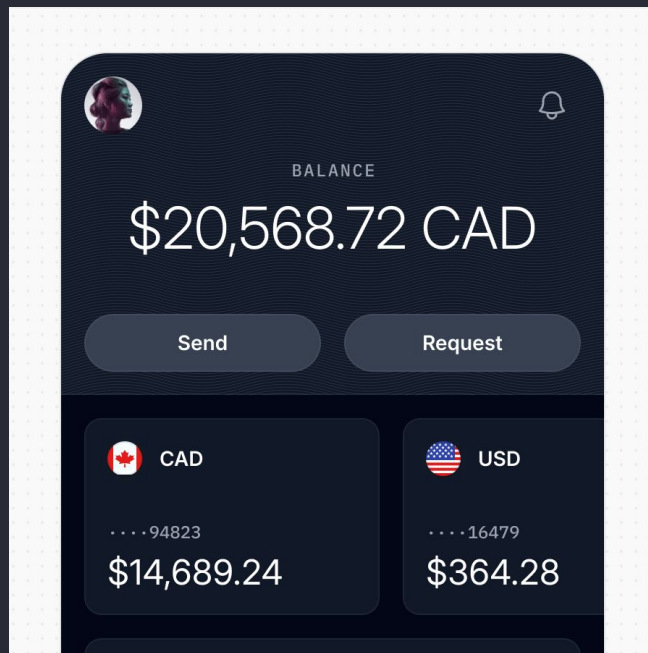
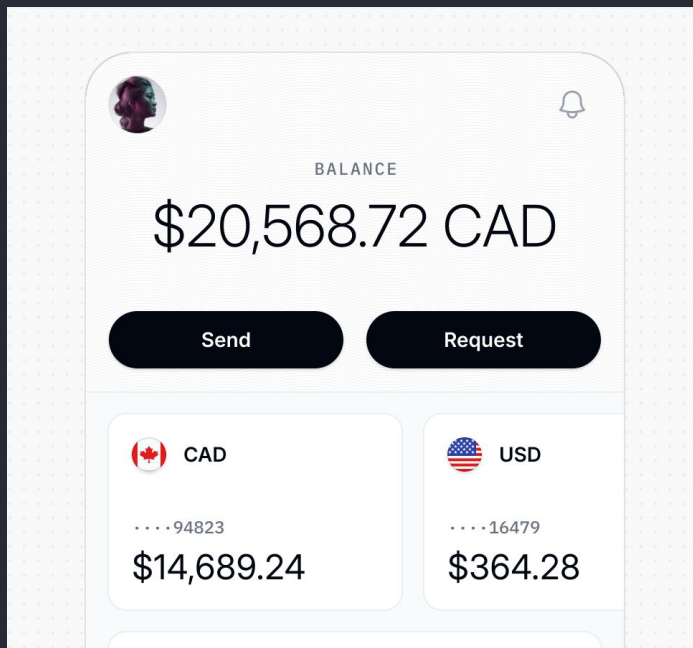
- Low sat → muted, elegant.
- High sat → energetic, playful.



Brightness in Practice

Light = open & spacious.

Dark = dramatic & focused.



Color harmony

- Complementary → max contrast
- Analogous → calm, unified
- Triadic → balanced variety



Complementary



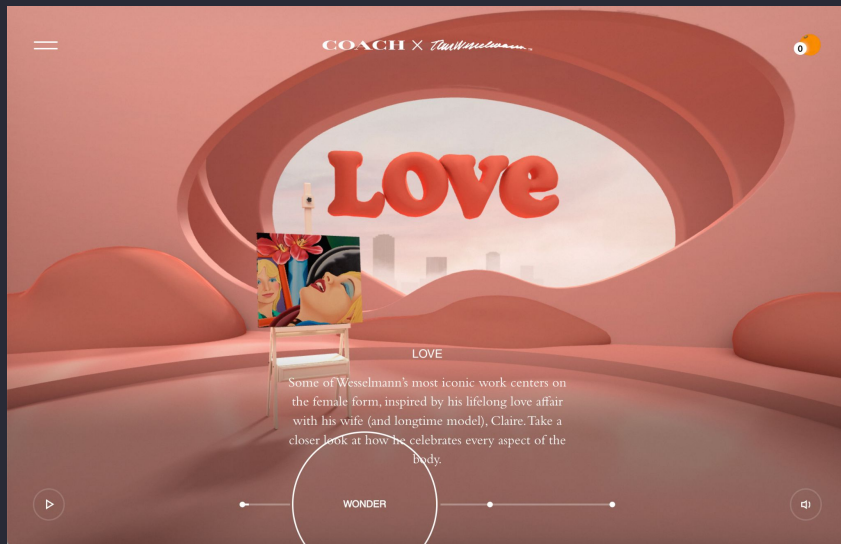
Analogous



Triadic

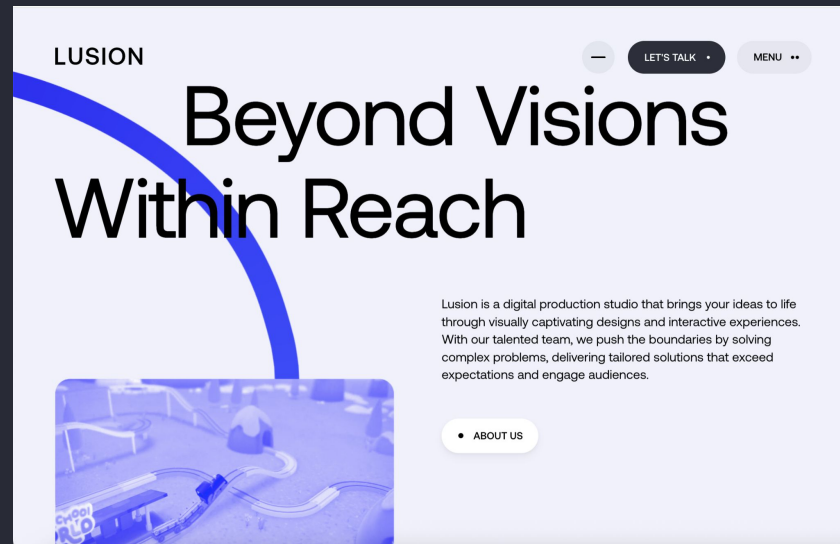


Emotional Associations



Warm colors: energy, passion, urgency.

<https://www.awwwards.com/sites/the-pleasure-pursuit>



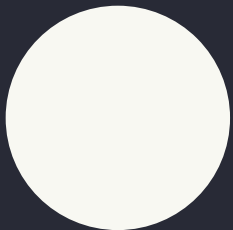
Cool colors: calm, trust, professionalism.

<https://www.awwwards.com/sites/lusion-v3>

Cultural differences



= love (West) / luck (China) / warning (UI)



= purity (West) / mourning (Asia)

Always test colors for target audience.

Colours In Culture



- | | | |
|----------------------|--------------------|----------------|
| A Western / American | 1 Anger | 19 Desire |
| B Japanese | 2 Art / Creativity | 20 Earthy |
| C Hindu | 3 Authority | 21 Energy |
| D Native American | 4 Bad Luck | 22 Erotic |
| E Chinese | 5 Balance | 23 Eternity |
| F Asian | 6 Beauty | 24 Evil |
| G Eastern European | 7 Calm | 25 Excitement |
| H Arab | 8 Celebration | 26 Family |
| I African | 9 Children | 27 Femininity |
| J South American | 10 Cold | 28 Fertility |
| | 11 Compassion | 29 Flamboyance |
| | 12 Courage | 30 Freedom |
| | 13 Cowardice | 31 Friendly |
| | 14 Cruelty | 32 Fun |
| | 15 Danger | 33 God |
| | 16 Death | 34 Gods |
| | 17 Decadence | 35 Good Luck |
| | 18 Deceit | 36 Gratitude |

- | | | |
|-----------------|-------------------|---------------------|
| 37 Growth | 55 Luxury | 73 Royalty |
| 38 Happiness | 56 Marriage | 74 Self-cultivation |
| 39 Healing | 57 Modesty | 75 Strength |
| 40 Healthy | 58 Money | 76 Style |
| 41 Heat | 59 Mourning | 77 Success |
| 42 Heaven | 60 Mystery | 78 Trouble |
| 43 Holiness | 61 Nature | 79 Truce |
| 44 Illness | 62 Passion | 80 Trust |
| 45 Insight | 63 Peace | 81 Unhappiness |
| 46 Intelligence | 64 Penance | 82 Virtue |
| 47 Intuition | 65 Power | 83 Warmth |
| 48 Religion | 66 Personal power | 84 Wisdom |
| 49 Jealousy | 67 Purity | |
| 50 Joy | 68 Radicalism | |
| 51 Learning | 69 Rational | |
| 52 Life | 70 Reliable | |
| 53 Love | 71 Repels Evil | |
| 54 Loyalty | 72 Respect | |

- | | |
|--------|--------|
| Yellow | Grey |
| Gold | Silver |

Brand color stories



red = excitement, appetite



green = creativity, energy



blue & yellow = trust + optimism

Accessible colors

Designing for clarity, inclusivity, and usability.

Add to cart

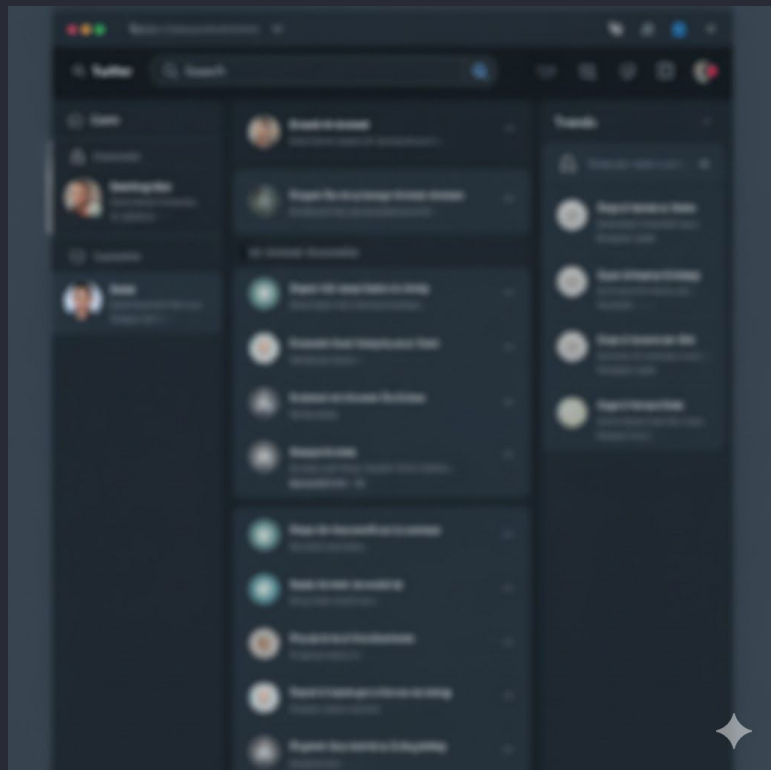
Add to cart

👉 If someone **can't read** your button, your design has **failed**

Why ally matters

- Around 1 in 12 men and 1 in 200 women have color vision deficiency.
- Accessibility is not just ethics — it's usability.
- High contrast improves readability for everyone.

What's wrong with that?



Contrast ratios & WCAG 2.2

- WCAG = Web Content Accessibility Guidelines
- AA: Normal text $\geq 4.5:1$, Large text $\geq 3:1$
- AAA: Normal text $\geq 7:1$, Large text $\geq 4.5:1$

Forget the numbers, use tools 

CONTRAST: 12.5:1
(LARGE TEXT)

 **PASS**

AAA Compliant

CONTRAST: 3.5:1
(NORMAL TEXT)

 **FAIL**

AA WCAG Failure

CONTRAST: 4.8:1
(NORMAL TEXT)

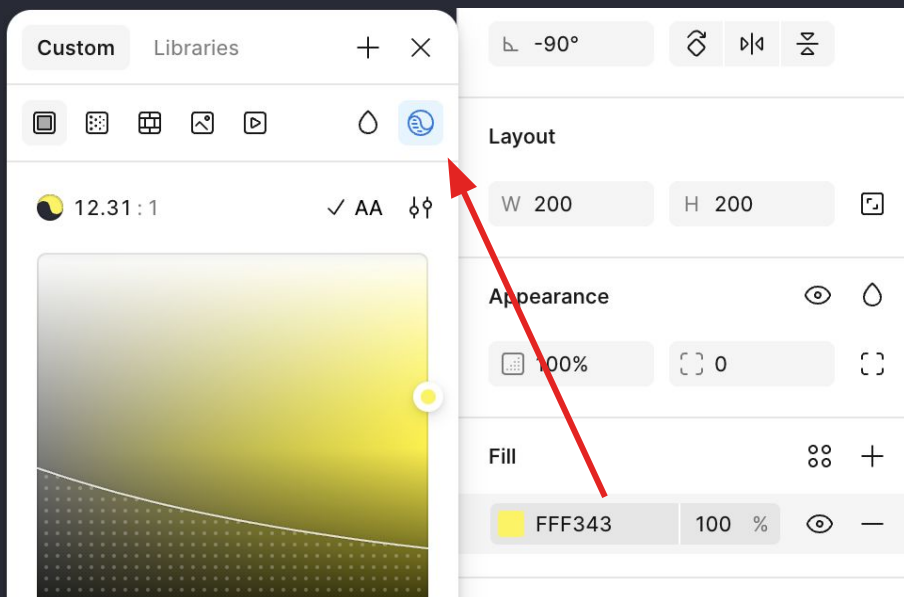
 **PASS**

AA Compliant



Tools

- WebAIM Contrast Checker: [WebAIM: Contrast Checker](https://webaim.org/contrast-checker/)
- Figma accessibility plugins (<https://www.getstark.co/> free tier)

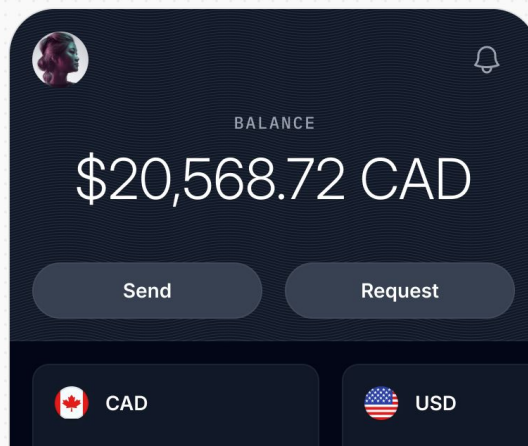
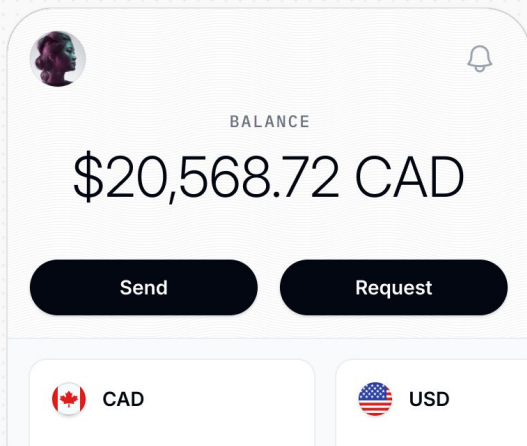


Build accessible color systems

- Define clear roles:
 - **Primary** – brand color (buttons, links)
 - **Secondary** – accents
 - **Neutral** – backgrounds, text, borders
- Test every text/background combination in your style guide.
- Save accessible pairs as Figma color styles.
CMD + K > “Toggle variables”

Light & dark mode

- Design needs to work in both contexts.
- Don't just invert colors → adjust saturation & brightness.
- Keep **contrast consistent** (especially text-on-background).



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Google Fonts and Color Tools

Google Fonts

- fonts.google.com
- No lorem ipsum. Use meaningful text
- Sans-serif or serif, higher number of styles makes it more flexible
- Variable fonts
- Choose 1 or max 2 fonts

Color palette tools

- <https://coolers.co/>
- Find a “mood”, fokus on one primary color that represents “you”
- Naming approaches of color variables
(<https://tailwindcss.com/docs/colors>)
 - orange-500 vs.
 - primary-500
- Color your design, walk away, re-iterate

Reduce text-over-image

- Hard to read and to get accessible
- Images and Text have to be very “optimized” to look good

Poor puppy



Summary

- Good typography **reinforces meaning** of text
- Design on 100% zoom
- Color psychology
- Simple set of fonts and colors
- Check the contrast

Inspiration Typography

- <https://fontsinuse.com/>
- <https://www.typewolf.com/>
- Type specimen
https://commercialtype.com/catalog/neue_haas_grotesk
- <https://practicaltypography.com/>

Inspiration Colors

- <https://coolors.co>
- <https://color.adobe.com>
- <http://colormind.io/>

Thanks!

